don’t think I can do this any longer—even my health is not good,’ he pleaded. For one final time, Sonia chose to ignore his request to quit.

In his final press conference, Dr Singh was a little more voluble than usual while defending himself. ‘I have served the country with utmost dedication and integrity,’ he said. ‘I do not believe that I have been a weak prime minister. I honestly believe that history will be kinder to me than the contemporary media or the Opposition in Parliament. Given the political compulsions, I have done the best I could do. It is for history to judge what I have done or what I have not done.’

How would history judge the man with the most famous blue turban? Indians tend to be kind to their leaders. In an opinion poll CNN-IBN conducted on the sixtieth anniversary of Indian Independence, Indira Gandhi emerged as the most admired politician. It was almost as if the Emergency had never happened. Dr Singh is unlikely to be put on the same pedestal. As a self-made man who had built his career though hard work and scholarship, there is much to admire about him. The fact that neither he nor his family derived any monetary benefit from his prime ministership is not insignificant either. In an age where corruption and nepotism in politics happily coexist, Dr Singh was able to retain a certain decency and moral commitment in his private life. Outside India, global leaders saw him as a man of rare intellect.

And yet, the fact is, when asked to stand up to corruption in his own government, he chose to look the other way. There were enough opportunities for him to say ‘enough is enough’ and draw a *Lakshman-rekha* when faced with the compulsions of coalition politics. Rather than exercise prime ministerial authority, as he did with the Indo-US nuclear deal, he fell back into the safety of his original avatar—a bureaucrat happy to take orders and simply stay in office, almost by force of habit or second nature. Yes, he did offer to resign on more than one occasion, but not once did he take the more courageous option of just walking away.

He was never a mass leader or an orator. He had lost the only Lok Sabha election he had contested, and seemed to prefer the sanctuary of the Rajya Sabha after that. In happier times, it did not really matter. In the crisis-